



School Leadership · Session 4

Learning Design

Students come first

Move from understanding to design without turning students into a list of problems.

Start with the real students you have in mind, a specific access question and evidence from your school-day map and audit. The design response comes after understanding.

Culture is something leaders shape

What staff say about students when they are not in the room follows what leaders model.

Staffroom language

Interrupt deficit talk kindly, every time.

What gets celebrated

Name inclusive practice publicly and specifically.

A vision staff can say

One sentence about inclusion that every staff member could repeat.

Your Autistic staff

A safe culture helps them too, disclosed or not.

Leaders set the conditions that make inclusive classrooms possible.

Resourcing as strategy

Where money and staff time go shows what the school values.

Support staff allocation

Is it based on need, or on habit?

Follow the evidence

Use your school-day map and audit to decide where support goes.

Low-cost changes

Warning time, a stable timetable and good templates cost little.

Records and funding

Good records of practice also support NCCD and funding.

Who decided your current support staff allocation, and when?

Leading change

Change that lasts usually starts small and visible.

Start with one system

Do it well and celebrate it.

Explain why

Staff need to know the reason for the change.

Support the middle

Resource and protect the staff who lead it day to day.

Review on a cycle

Check what is working and adjust.

Staff follow what leaders do more than what they write.

How this session runs

Short inputs, then doing. You work in trios on one school system.

1

Start

14 min · Three inputs,
then move

2

Brief

6 min · Trios

3

Options

12 min · Input, then trios

4

Universal first

6 min · Trios

5

Design

12 min · Trios

6

Check

5 min · On your own,
private

7

Continuum

7 min · Input

8

Gallery and commit

9 min · Whole room

You will leave with one school change, planned for this term, this year and the strategic plan.

Regroup

Bring back your Carry into design card from Session 3.

Move to the corner of the room for the system you want to work on:

Culture and learning

Routines

Teams and resourcing

Form a trio with two people near you. Each of you keeps your own school and your students in mind.

5 minutes

Keep your students in view

Hold a concise picture of each of the students you have in mind, including:

**Strengths, interests
and joy**

**Communication,
sensory experience
and thinking**

**What costs and what
lightens**

Identity and belonging

**What students,
families and the team
already know**

**Questions that remain
open**

You are not building a file on one child. Keep real, different students in view as you design.

Write your trio's brief

Agree on one school system you all recognise, then write an environment-first brief.

At the moment, this system asks students to...

For some students and staff, that means...

We could change...

Check the wording: is it specific, workable and free from blame or deficit labels?

Options menu

Four short inputs. Listen for what might answer your brief.

1

Professional learning and coaching

Staff learning that continues through the year

2

Predictability as policy

Relief-day plans, change warnings, a stable timetable

3

Inclusion team and review cycles

Adjustments planned and reviewed on a schedule

4

Documentation that helps staff

Templates, profiles that travel, a resource bank

Printed option cards are on your table. After the inputs, your trio chooses one or two.

Professional learning and coaching

Build staff learning into the year:

Learning that continues after today

Coaching and mentoring in classrooms

Time to plan and review together

A mentor for every early career teacher

Today is one step. Plan what comes next for your staff.

Predictability as policy

Predictability includes clear information about routine and change.

Can every student, and every relief teacher, answer:



**What is
happening?**



**What is
changing?**



**What comes
next?**



**What can I do if
the plan
changes?**

Relief-day plans, change warnings and a stable timetable are school decisions.

Inclusion team and review cycles

A small team that plans, reviews and retires adjustments on a schedule, not only when there is a crisis.

Decide who is on it, how often it meets, how students and families are included, and how decisions reach every teacher.

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Image placeholder

Who reviews adjustments in your school, and how often?

Documentation that helps staff

Image placeholder

Templates and tools

Profiles that travel, adjustment records and a resource bank staff will use.

Documentation should help staff do the right thing without adding paperwork.

Keep templates short, store them where staff will find them, and make sure information about a student reaches every teacher who needs it.

Quick review of your documentation

- Can staff find it when they need it?
- Is it short enough to use?
- Does it reflect what is happening now?
- Does it reach relief teachers?

Choose your options

Which one or two options answer your brief?

☐

Professional learning and coaching

Staff learning that continues through the year

☐

Predictability as policy

Relief-day plans, change warnings, a stable timetable

☐

Inclusion team and review cycles

Adjustments planned and reviewed on a schedule

☐

Documentation that helps staff

Templates, profiles that travel, a resource bank

Write down why the option fits: which demand in your school does it answer?

Record your choice, and why, on your A3 sheet, section 2.

Universal Design for Learning

Apply a Universal Design for Learning lens to the emerging design:

- Make important information clear and available
- Offer workable ways to participate and respond
- Support engagement without removing meaningful challenge

Individual knowledge and universal design can inform each other.



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Accessibility check

Run these over your draft design, then test it through use and feedback.

☐ Can students find and understand what they need?

☐ Can they take part in more than one way?

☐ Can they pause, ask for help or recover?

☐ Is the support available when demand increases?

Design your school change

As a trio, develop the change on your A3 sheet, section 4.

- 1 This term: a decision that costs little.
- 2 This year: what you will build.
- 3 The strategic plan: what makes it last.
- 4 Decide what you will observe.
- 5 Set a time to review.

Ask the trio next to you to check the design remains student-centred.

Check the design against your students

On your own card, test your trio’s design against each of your students.

	Helps	No difference	Needs something more
Student A			
Student B			
Student C			

Where the design still doesn’t work for someone, that is where targeted or individual support begins.

Continuum of support

Support is a continuum rather than a single intervention.

1

Inclusive environment

First, design inclusive environments that reduce barriers for everyone.

2

Universal supports

Then, provide universal supports that many students may benefit from.

3

Targeted supports

Next, offer targeted supports for students who need additional assistance.

4

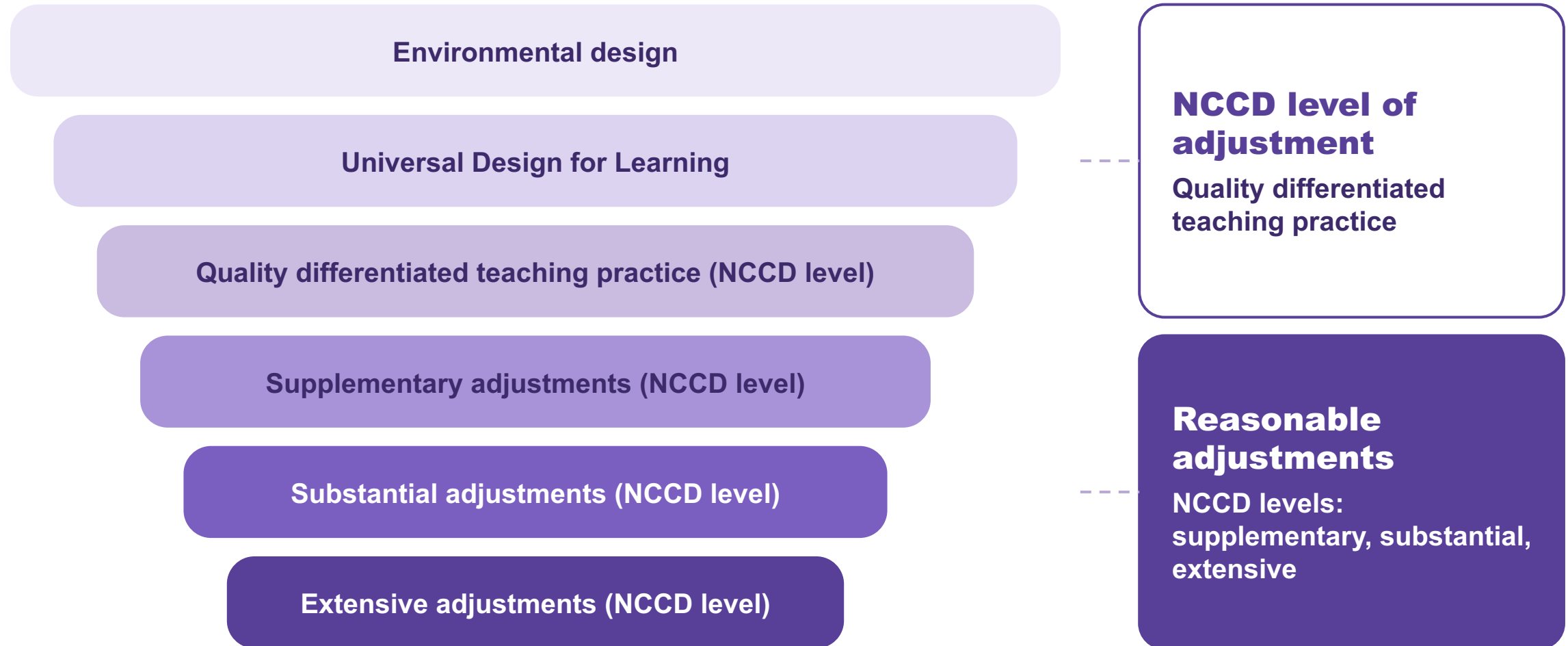
Individual adjustments

Finally, where necessary, implement individual adjustments to ensure equitable access, participation and learning.

Academic adjustments sit within a wider continuum of support.

Consider what is available to everyone, what is targeted and what is individually adjusted. Each response should connect to access and participation needs and be reviewed through use and feedback.

Reasonable Adjustments



NCCD

NCCD information and links

Good practice creates the evidence: consultation records, documented adjustments and review cycles. Leaders decide what evidence staff gather and how easy it is to record. Follow your school or system processes.

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Gallery walk

See what other trios designed.

- 1 Put your A3 design on the wall.
- 2 Walk the gallery. On another trio's design, leave a Post-it: one idea you would borrow, or one question.
- 3 Return to your own design and read what others left.

9 minutes, with commit

Share, refine and commit



After the gallery, ask yourself:

- What will you start this term?
- What will you notice?
- Who on your executive will you share it with?
- How will students and families help refine it?

Treat the change as something to try, review and refine.